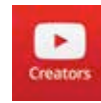


What is Brexit?

Google search results analytics shows many UK voters didn't understand Brexit and started to look it up only after they had voted. <http://dgit.in/BrexitGglT>



Rejoice YT Creators!

With better creators support, YouTube has added many such new features to its Creator Hub launched at VidCon. <http://dgit.in/YtCrtr>

and explored. An interesting story about a fully automated future home sounds nice, but before you automate your home, you need to do some analysis and understand what actually can be automated right now. You also need to determine to what degree you want your home to be automated. When it comes to devices, the essential categories are as follows -

- **Entrance Management** - Digital door locks with audio/video support
- **Security** - Panic buttons, sensors that detect gas leaks, heat, fire, intrusion, motion
- **Device Control** - Smart switches, smart lights, thermostats, sprinklers, automated devices
- **Scene and Entertainment management** - Saving and using profiles for multiple devices (like party mode), connected home entertainment system.

Automate how?

Whenever the topic of home automation comes up, one of the first topics of concern is connectivity. After all, you aren't replacing everything in your home with completely new gadgets that have totally new methods of operation! You're simply trying to automate the existing ones, and for that you need connectivity. There are mainly two ways in which home automation companies are approaching this. Let us find out more about both of them.

Local Wi-Fi+Internet connectivity with centralised hub

This approach usually involves installing a central hub somewhere in your home and allowing it to use your local Wi-Fi to connect to all the smart devices intended towards automation. The devices, on the other hand, will also be connected to the same Wi-Fi network. The on-board receivers will receive commands and the transmitters will provide status and usage data. And if the local network setup has internet access, most such setups can be controlled via an accompanying app, which more often than not forms the basis of controlling your smart home.

This Wi-Fi setup works in tandem with each device and its components. For example, converting a regular switch-

board to a smart switch mostly involves inserting a separate switch controller module behind the switchboard. This module can receive on and off commands from the hub, and some can even support dimmer switches. A smart door lock would use image processing locally to identify a person at the door and control the locking mechanism accordingly. The lock can detect a forced intrusion if any and send you an alert on your phone via the hub. It completely depends on the implemented device as to how it will put the connectivity to use.

Infrared remote operated

Almost every device around the house is connected to a plug, and if it is not (like a curtain) then the process of automation might require it to be connected to one. And there are companies that are manufacturing plugs and switches with infrared sensors so that they can be controlled via IR blasters on smartphones or proprietary remotes provided by the manufacturer. This method often accompanies the Wi-Fi method as an additional perk, also because it is often the faster alternative. Although, this is not entirely applicable to devices that need more than a turn on/turn off functionality.

Indian automators

If what you've read so far makes you wish to visit your local market and buy some home automation stuff, hold onto your horses! Some of the best home automation solutions in India are being created by startups. Take Air from Leaf Technolo-



Air from Leaf Technologies has the looks and the features to make it a good choice

gies. It is a hub-based home automation system that comes with a slew of smart switches of various power levels and dimmable options. The first thing that you will notice is the design on this device. It is not just another bulky device that you will have to hide behind some box or panels in your home, you would want to flaunt this. Once you put that aside, this device does have features that puts it higher than just a smart switch controller. Air lets you lock your appliances so that they can't be used if you are away and alerts you about any intrusion once security mode is activated (using its motion and presence detectors). The switchboard also serves the purpose of a surge protector with its internal fuse and switches off devices when the hub senses that nobody is in the room. Most importantly, the accompanying smartphone app tries to learn your preferences and can schedule repetitive tasks.

There are a number of options available which operate like Air, such as Cubical switches from Cubical technologies. Devoid of the advanced sensors, they are priced more flexibly between ₹6,000 and ₹14,000 depending on the number of switches you choose and if you choose a cam at all. eGlu from Wizr systems takes this slightly further by throwing in smart tags and panic buttons as well. It lets you figure out the connections by yourself if you want, although we cannot assure you if it is truly DIY as it is not released yet.

There are some providers who are doing more than smart switches. Silvan home automation solutions is an overall home automation product that is designed to be incorporated right from the construction of the house. They have already worked with Lodha builders and Tata Housing, so they have already bagged in big clients. They offer products in all four of the categories that we mentioned earlier, although the pricing is only available on consultation. They are also into board room automation, hotel room automation, school security etc. This might be a good balance between comprehensive solutions and technical innovations, for instance, their smart camera can detect people loitering around your premises and send you alerts accordingly.